

Initial Vowel and Prefix Tone in Kom: Related to the Bantu Augment?

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1. Introduction

Over the course of our research in Cameroon in the 1970s and 1980s, various members of the Grassfields Bantu Working Group speculated that certain tonal alternations on noun prefixes constituted evidence for an earlier high (H) tone augment. Noun prefixes in both the Ring and Momo subbranches of Grassfields Bantu (GB) generally have underlying /H/ tone in citation forms and most grammatical contexts. At the same time, however, and without exception, nouns exhibit a low (L) tone prefix when occurring after an associative marker in an ‘N1 of N2’ construction. It has thus been tempting to view the H tone as an additional morpheme, perhaps related to the Proto-Bantu H tone V-/CV- augment reconstructed by Meeussen (1967). Although best known from detailed descriptions of Eastern Bantu languages such as Luganda (J15) and Cibemba (M42), we know from studies such as Grégoire & Janssens (1999) that different but comparable phenomena are found in Northwest Bantu, if not elsewhere in Bantoid and Benue-Congo (Williamson 1993). In the GB cases, evidence has been primarily tonal. Since we are dealing only with the difference between an underlying /H/ vs. /L/ tone prefix, the position that /H/ relates to the Proto-Bantu augment would have to be carefully argued.

In this paper I begin in §2 by examining the realization of noun prefixes in Kom, a GB language of the Ring subgroup (Hyman 1980a, Stallcup 1980, Watters & Leroy 1989, Watters 2003). In this language, CV- prefixes are sometimes preceded by an additional schwa (orthographic ‘e’), e.g., /t^é-b^ĩĩ/, /é-t^é-b^ĩĩ/, ‘kolanuts’ (class 13). In addition, whether the tone of a noun prefix will be /H/ vs. /L/ depends on a number of factors. In §3 I comment on the relation of the Kom initial vowel and tone facts to those found in other Ring languages. In §4 I present a set of hypotheses that would account for these facts. I conclude in §5 by considering an alternative proposal of Hombert (1976) and Williamson (1993).¹

1. The data presented here were collected on fields trips to Bamenda in 1974 and 1977 and further investigated with additional speakers of Kom in Los Angeles during the late 1970s and early 1980s. I am especially grateful to those who have helped me with my studies on Kom, including Thomas Tingem, Jili Ngwainbi, Emmanuel Chia, Emmanuel Chiabi, Emmanuel Mbeng, and Patience Yuh, as well as to the members of the Grassfields Bantu Working Group who participated in our comparative project. After writing the first draft of this paper Roger Blench kindly brought two important references to my attention, Schulz (1997) and Jones (2001), which readers can also consult for further exemplification.

2. The Kom data

Kom (GFW 822) is the major language of the centre branch of the Ring subgroup of Western Grassfields Bantu (WGB), with an estimated 127,000 speakers as of 1982 (Grimes *et al.* 2000). Within the group its morphology is relatively conservative. As the following noun + adjective phrase illustrates, words in Kom can be highly agglutinative with both prefixal and suffixal noun class marking:

(1) Noun + adjective:

e-te-bíí te-béé-lé-né-té 'big kolanuts'

(e-te-bíí, 'kolanuts'; e-, 'initial vowel'; te-/te, 'class 13 agreement'; -béé-, 'big', -lé- [lɛ̃], 'pluractional suffix'; -né- [nɛ̃], 'deverbal adjectivizer')

As seen above, the noun e-te-bíí (underlyingly /é-té-bíí/) begins with an initial vowel /é-/ followed by the class 13 noun class prefix /té-. The adjective is derived from the verb béé, 'be big', and begins with the same class 13 prefix, followed by three suffixes: pluractional /-lé-/, the deverbal adjectivizer /-né-/, and a class 13 suffix /-té/. As background, the noun class and tone systems of Kom are briefly outlined in the following two subsections.

2.1. Noun classes

The noun classes and markers we will be concerned with are indicated in Table 1.

class	noun affix	SP	AM	adjective	example	gloss
1	Ø, w-	wũ	è	è- ... Ø	wáyn	'child'
2	Ø, gh(e)-	ghé	é	ghé- ... -é	ghóyn	'children'
3	e- (*)	wú	é	é- (*) ... -é	e-lwéñ	'bamboo'
4	i-	yí	í	í- ... -í	i-léñ	'bamboos'
5	i-	yí	í	í ... -í	i-sóñ	'tooth'
6	a-	ké	á	á ... -á	a-sóñ	'teeth'
7	a-	ké	á	á ... -á	a-tā?	'snail'
8	e- (*)	wú	é	é- (*) ... -é	e-twā?	'snails'
9	Ø	yì	è	ì ... Ø	bí	'dog'
10	Ø ... -sé	sé	sé	sé ... -sé	bí-se	'dogs'
13	te-	té	té	té ... -té	te-bíí	'kolanuts'
19	fe-	fé	fé	fé ... -fé	fe-nywíñ	'bird'
6a	me-	mè	mè	èN ... -`	me-nywíñ	'birds'

Table 1. Noun classes and representative agreements

The seven columns in Table 1 provide the following information:

- (i) The number of the noun class. Kom has reflexes of Bantu classes 1-10, 13, 19, and 6a (the last of which being distinguished from class 6).
- (ii) The affix marking the class on the noun itself. There are three possibilities: no affix (classes, 1, 2, 9); a suffix (class 10); a prefix (classes 3-8, 10, 13, 19, 6a).² Class 1/2 is a relatively small and irregular gender; cf. *lóm*, 'husband', *ghé-lóm*, 'husbands'. In the case of the *e-*(^w) prefix of classes 3 and 8, the ^w stands for the labializing or labiodentalizing effect on the first consonant of the stem. No tone is given on the noun class prefixes, since this is the subject of the present study (cf. §2.3). The class 10 suffix *-sé*, on the other hand, clearly carries an underlying H (high) tone, which, however, undergoes the regular tone rules of the language (cf. §2.2).
- (iii) Subject pronouns corresponding to each class. These are of the structure CV for each class. Classes 1, 9, and 6a differ from the others in having an L (low) tone as opposed to the others' H tone subject pronoun.
- (iv) Associative marker (AM): This is the marker that appears between an N1 and N2 in an 'N1 of N2' associative (connective, genitive) construction. Again, classes 1, 9, and 6a are L, while other classes are H.
- (v) Adjective agreement. As the example in (1) illustrates, adjectives take both a prefix and suffix concord. The exceptions are classes 1 and 9, which take no suffix concord. Class 6a is interesting in that it takes an *eN-* prefix (with a homorganic nasal), but only an L tone suffix: *e-fé-tám fé-béé-né-fé*, 'big fruit', or *e-me-tám em-bee-lé-nê*, 'big fruits' (< *-né-*).³
- (vi) and (vii) An example with its gloss is given for each noun class. I follow Chia's (1984) orthographic suggestions with some exceptions. The most important of these is that I use 'e' to stand for a rather close schwa in affixes.³ The nouns are presented without the initial vowel mentioned in §1. Forms with an initial vowel will be exemplified and discussed in §2.3.

2.2. Tone

Like other GB languages, Kom has two underlying tones, H and L. It also exhibits an M (mid) tone on the surface. HM and ML falling tones are also robustly attested, while LM and MH rising tones are marginal. There are two sources of M tone: (i) an H tone-bearing unit is pronounced M after an L; (ii) H prefixes are pronounced M in almost all contexts, e.g., /*f é-tám*/ 'fruit' is

2. As in other WGB languages, slightly more than half of the 9/10 nouns in Kom begin with a NC cluster, e.g., *ngv i*, 'hen'; *ndoŋ*, 'horn'; and *njám*, 'axe'. Remaining nouns lack this nasal: *lóm*, 'dry season'; *kāy n*, 'monkey'; and *gwén*, 'farm'. Synchronically, the nasal can be considered part of the stem.

3. In these examples, *gh* = [ɣ] and *ny* = [ɲ]. Tones are marked as follows: High (ˊ), Low (ˋ), pre-pausing non-falling Low (ˊˋ), Mid (ˊˊ) when occurring in a contour, otherwise unmarked. Tonal contours are indicated by combinations of the above tone marks, although for orthographic reasons, the second tone may slightly follow a short vowel, e.g., *séˊˋ*, 'to'.

pronounced [fē-tām]. By this criterion, the subject pronouns and AMs, which are pronounced H unless preceded by an L tone, are not prefixes: M tone is unmarked unless forming an HM or ML contour, in which case a macron is used, e.g., fe-nyūyñ fē fēñ fēē, ‘a bird is falling’ (where the fe- prefix on ‘bird’ is also M tone).

Since most noun stems are monosyllabic, and most nouns have a prefix, most nouns will be bisyllabic. The four most common tone patterns on bisyllabic nouns are seen in (2).

(2) The four most common tone patterns on bisyllabic nouns (prefix + stem):

- | | | | | | |
|----|--------------------|---|----------|-----------|--------|
| a. | /fe-gham/
H L | → | fe-ghām | ‘mat’ | (M-HL) |
| b. | /fe-nywin/
H LH | → | fe-nywīñ | ‘bird’ | (M-HM) |
| c. | /fe-bu?/
H HL | → | fe-bú? | ‘gorilla’ | (M-H) |
| d. | /fe-tam/
H H | → | fe-tām | ‘fruit’ | (M-H) |

The prefix /fē-/ is realized M in all four nouns. In addition, (2a) and (2b) show that the H of the prefix spreads to the following L or LH syllable to form an HL and HM contour, respectively.

(3) H tone spreading (HTS):

- | | | | |
|----|---|----|--|
| a. | $\begin{array}{c} \text{fe-ghām} \\ \swarrow \quad \searrow \\ \text{H} \quad \text{L} \end{array}$ | b. | $\begin{array}{c} \text{fe-nywīñ} \\ \swarrow \quad \searrow \quad \swarrow \\ \text{H} \quad \text{L} \quad \text{H} \end{array}$ |
|----|---|----|--|

In (3a) the H of the prefix /fē-/ spreads onto the L stem /-ghām/, creating an HL falling tone. This is followed by initial lowering of the prefix to M. The same HTS rule applies in (3b). In this case, the L of the LH stem delinks. As a result, not only is the prefix realized M, but so is the second half of the stem, conditioned by the delinked, floating L tone, which must remain for this purpose.

We have not yet seen the evidence that (2c) and (2d) need to be distinguished. Both are realized M-H in isolation, but when placed in context, differences are observed, as in (4).

(4) Two kinds of M-H nouns:

- | | | | | | |
|----|--------|----|-----|-----|------------------------|
| a. | fe-bú? | fe | fēñ | fēē | ‘a gorilla is falling’ |
| | H HL | H | | | |
| b. | fe-tām | fē | fēñ | fēē | ‘a fruit is falling’ |
| | H H | H | | | |

In (4a), the class 19 H tone subject pronoun /fɛ-/ is pronounced M because of the floating L of the HL stem -bú?̃, ‘gorilla’. This lowering to M does not occur in (4b), because the stem -tám, ‘fruit’, does not have a floating L after it. A further difference between these two nouns is observed in (5).⁴

(5) Derivations with HTS and LTS:

- a. ne fɛ-gham -fɛ → nɛ̃ fɛ̃-ghām -fɛ̃° ‘with a mat’
 | | | | | | | |
 L H L H L H L H
- b. ne fɛ-nywɪn -fɛ → nɛ̃ fɛ̃-nywɪn -fɛ̃ ‘with a bird’
 | | / | | | | / | |
 L H L H H L H L H H
- c. ne fɛ-bu? -fɛ → nɛ̃ fɛ̃-bú? -fɛ ‘with a gorilla’
 | | | | | | | |
 L H HL H L H HL H
- d. ne fɛ-tám -fɛ → nɛ̃ fɛ̃-tám -fɛ̃ ‘with a fruit’
 | | | | | | | |
 L H H H L H H H

These examples involve the preposition nɛ̃, ‘with’, which requires a suffix identical to that occurring on adjectives (see Table 1). Rather significant tonal alternations occur. Let us begin with (5d). Here we see that the L of /nɛ̃/ spreads onto the prefix /fɛ̃-/, thereby delinking its H. We refer to this rule as L tone spreading (LTS). The output is thus as expected: the first two syllables are L. Although the stem -tám directly follows a surface L tone, it is pronounced with H tone (rather than M), because of the delinked floating H. The same facts are observed in (5c), except that the suffix /-fɛ̃/ is pronounced with M tone. This is of course attributable to the L of /-bú?̃/. What needs to be added, however, is that a floating L does not condition LTS.

Turning now to (5a), whose input is /L-H-L-H/, we see that each of the first three tones spreads one syllable to the right. In both cases of LTS, the following H is delinked. The H of /fɛ̃-/ is preserved on the stem /-ghām/, where it has spread. The resulting falling tone is pronounced ML rather than HL because of the preceding L. Where L spreads on to the suffix /-fɛ̃/, the delinked H floats. In this case we obtain a level L tone, indicated by °. Whereas a normal L downglides before the pause, this L remains level because of the H that floats after it. L° can therefore be viewed as an ‘unreleased’ L tone.

Finally, (5b) shows LTS from /nɛ̃/ as well as HTS of the prefix /fɛ̃-/. With the proper delinking of the H and L, as shown, we obtain two H tones linked to

4. I am side-stepping a number of issues here which are not relevant to the paper. For example, I start with the LH of the stem linked to -nywɪn in (5b), but only the H of the HL linked to the stem -bu? in (5c).

the stem *-nywín*. Since they are each preceded by an L, the two links are both pronounced M.

As we have seen, the M tone rule operates late in Kom tonology following the application of HTS and LTS. Although the underlyingly /H/ prefixes in (1)–(5) are pronounced either M or L, we do not want to confuse these alternations with those that result from different underlying tones on noun prefixes. We turn to this issue in the next subsection.

2.3. Prefix tone

In all of the examples seen thus far, the underlying tone on the noun prefixes has been /H/. As was stated, prefixal /H/ is realized mid on the surface—but not before it has been able to spread an H feature on to a following L tone stem, e.g., /fɛ́-ghâm/ → fɛ́-ghâm → fɛ-ghâm, ‘mat’ (M-HL). In fact, depending on lexical and grammatical factors, a noun prefix may be underlyingly /H/ or /L/. The grammatical factors are summarized in Table 2.

classes	general	with IV	associative	as subject
1, 9, 6a	H	H	L	L
other	H	H	L	H

Table 2. Underlying tones of noun prefixes

As indicated, prefix tone may be grammatically assigned in one of three ways: /H/ in all noun classes, /L/ in all noun classes, and /L/ vs. /H/ depending on noun class. Examples are seen in Table 3.

class	general	with IV	associative	subject	gloss
1	wáyn	e-wáyn	wáyn°	wáyn°	‘child’
2	ghóyn	e-ghóyn	ghòyn°	ghóyn	‘children’
3	e-lwéŋ	e-lwéŋ	è-lwèŋ°	e-lwéŋ	‘bamboo’
4	i-léŋ	i-léŋ	ì-lèŋ°	i-léŋ	‘bamboos’
5	i-sóŋ	i-sóŋ	ì-sòŋ°	i-sóŋ	‘tooth’
6	a-sóŋ	a-sóŋ	à-sòŋ°	a-sóŋ	‘teeth’
7	a-tâ?	a-tâ?	à-tâ?	a-tâ?	‘snail’
8	e-twâ?	e-twâ?	è-twâ?	e-twâ?	‘snails’
9	bí	e-bí	bí	bí	‘dog’
10	bí-se	e-bí-se	bí-se	bí-se	‘dogs’
13	te-bíí	e-te-bíí	tè-bíí°	te-bíí	‘kolanuts’
19	fe-nywín	e-fe-nywín	fè-nywín°	fe-nywín	‘bird’
6a	me-nywín	e-me-nywín	mè-nywín°	mè-nywín°	‘birds’

Table 3. Illustrations of nouns in four contexts

The general forms with /H/ prefixes are found in object position. We also saw in (5) that these forms occur after the preposition *nè*, ‘with’, although the /H/ is delinked by LTS. Speakers may also pronounce these forms in isolation, although they are much more likely to use the initial vowel shown in the second column in Table 3. Except when the noun phrase is the subject of a main clause, the initial vowel occurs only at the beginning of an intonational phrase: ‘This preprefix occurs only when the noun is in isolation (or in a list). It does not occur [internally] in sentences and should therefore not be written in sentences’ (Chia 1984:32).

As seen in Table 3, the initial vowel consists of a schwa prefix *e-*, which is directly observable before the above consonant-initial nouns in classes 1, 2, 9, and 10, as well as before the CV- prefixes in classes 13, 19, 6a, and 2a, when the latter has a *ghe-* prefix, e.g., *e-ghe-lóm*, ‘husbands’. When a noun has an /H/ vowel prefix, there is no difference between the general and IV forms. However, among a corpus of 247 bisyllabic nouns, 29 (or approximately 12%) have an /L/ tone prefix. In this case, as indicated in Table 4, it is possible to distinguish general from IV forms.

class	general	with IV	associative	subject	gloss
1	(Ø prefix)				
2	<i>ghè-nà</i>	<i>e-ghè-nà</i>	<i>ghè-nà</i>	<i>ghè-nà</i>	‘mothers’
3	<i>è-ŋkòyn</i> ^o	<i>e-è-ŋkòyn</i> ^o	<i>è-ŋkòyn</i> ^o	<i>è-ŋkòyn</i> ^o	‘tail’
4	(none)				
5	<i>ì-ncià</i>	<i>i-ì-ncià</i>	<i>ì-ncià</i>	<i>ì-ncià</i>	‘sting’
6	(none)				
7	<i>à-ncès</i>	<i>a-à-ncès</i>	<i>à-ncès</i>	<i>à-ncès</i>	‘cricket’
8	<i>è-ncwès</i>	<i>e-è-ncwès</i>	<i>è-ncwès</i>	<i>è-ncwès</i>	‘crickets’
9	(Ø prefix)				
10	(Ø prefix)				
13	<i>tè-ncià</i>	<i>e-tè-ncià</i>	<i>tè-ncià</i>	<i>tè-ncià</i>	‘stings’
19	<i>fè-bòyn</i>	<i>e-fè-bòyn</i>	<i>fè-bòyn</i>	<i>fè-bòyn</i>	‘ground squirrel’
6a	<i>mè-bòyn</i>	<i>e-mè-bòyn</i>	<i>mè-bòyn</i>	<i>mè-bòyn</i>	‘ground squirrels’

Table 4. Illustrations of nouns with /L/ prefixes

Although most nouns with an /L/ prefix begin with a NC cluster, there are exceptions, e.g., *a-à-tàm*, ‘elephant’.⁵ While I write *a-à-ncès* with an ML vowel sequence, the fall to L tone is heard on the nasal (when present), i.e. *a-ñcès*. Only a handful of NC-initial nouns take an /H/ prefix, e.g., */é-fé-njèn/* → *e-fe-njèn*, ‘star’. Class 9/10 nouns which begin NC do not incur a fall to L when the initial vowel is added: *e-ndo*, ‘house’; *e-mbam*, ‘snake’.

5. Curiously, the L conditioned by the NC initial does not always spread into a following H stem or condition H to M lowering, e.g., */á-à-ŋkém/*, ‘crab’ → *a-à-ŋkém*, not **a-à-ŋkèm*^o or **a-à-ŋkém*. For further examples, see Schulz (1997).

The nouns in Table 4 show that the initial vowel has /H/ tone, while their prefix has /L/. By extension, we can see that the initial vowel and prefix are H not only in e-Ce- sequences with M-M tone in Table 3, but also in V-V-, which simplifies to a single V- with M tone.

I will defer further discussion of the initial vowel until §3.1. More important at this point is to consider the remaining columns of Tables 3 and 4. The associative column shows all noun prefixes to be /L/. This is common in WGB and has been described in a number of other languages of both the Ring and Momo subgroups. To show this, we shall use the possessor nouns in (6), which correspond tonally to the four nouns seen above in (2).

(6) The four most common tone patterns on possessor nouns:

- | | | | | | |
|----|------------------|---|---------|------------|--------|
| a. | /te-foyn/
H L | → | te-fôyn | ‘chiefs’ | (M-HL) |
| b. | /te-dzi/
H LH | → | te-dzĩĩ | ‘termites’ | (M-HM) |
| c. | /te-bal/
H HL | → | te-bál | ‘valleys’ | (M-H) |
| d. | /te-wu/
H H | → | te-wú | ‘rocks’ | (M-H) |

The nouns in (6) all have an underlyingly /H/ prefix. As before, (6c) and (6d) are equivalent in isolation, but have different tonal properties in context.

Now compare how these same prefixes are realized in (7), where they follow the class 6a L tone AM mè:

(7) Class 6a múū mè, ‘water of’, followed by four possessor tone patterns:

- | | | | | | |
|----|------------------|----------------|---|-----------------|----------------------------|
| a. | múū me
H LH L | te-foyn
L L | → | múū mè tè-fôyn | ‘water of chiefs’ (L-L) |
| b. | múū me
H LH L | te-dzi
L LH | → | múū mè tè-dzĩĩ° | ‘water of termites’ (L-L°) |
| c. | múū me
H LH L | te-bal
L HL | → | múū mè tè-bal | ‘water of valleys’ (L-M) |
| d. | múū me
H LH L | te-wu
L H | → | múū mè tè-wú° | ‘water of rocks’ (L-L°) |

Whereas the tone of te-fôyn, ‘chiefs’, was M-HL in (6a), its tone is L-L in (7a). Similarly, te-dzĩĩ, ‘termites’, has M-HM in (6b), but L-L° in (7b). Both of these realizations follow directly from an /L/ prefix on these nouns. The L-L° tone of ‘termites’ is due to the floating H, as we have seen elsewhere. In (7c), ‘valleys’ is pronounced L-M instead of the M-H seen in (6c). In contrast, LTS

applies instead to ‘rocks’ in (7d). We thus obtain L-L° instead of the M-H observed in (6d). LTS fails to apply in (7c) because of the floating L of /-bā́l̩/.

Nouns of all classes have an /L/ prefix following AMs. While this is seen clearly in (7), where the class 6a AM is L tone, the underlying /L/ undergoes HTS when preceded by an H tone AM, such as class 10 sɛ́ in (8).

(8) Class 10 soyn sɛ́ ‘friends of’ followed by four possessor tone patterns:

- | | | | | | | | | | |
|----|------|----|---------|---|------|-----|---------|-----------------------|---------|
| a. | soyn | se | te-foyn | → | sóŷn | sɛ́ | tê-fòyn | ‘friends of chiefs’ | (HL-L) |
| | H | LH | H L L | | | | | | |
| b. | soyn | se | te-dzi | → | sóŷn | sɛ́ | tê-dzĩ° | ‘friends of termites’ | (HL-L°) |
| | H | LH | H L LH | | | | | | |
| c. | soyn | se | te-bal | → | sóŷn | sɛ́ | tê-bal | ‘friends of valleys’ | (HL-M) |
| | H | LH | H L HL | | | | | | |
| d. | soyn | se | te-wu | → | sóŷn | sɛ́ | tê-wũ° | ‘friends of rocks’ | (HL-L°) |
| | H | LH | H L H | | | | | | |

As indicated, the H of the class 10 AM sɛ́ spreads on to the L tẽ- prefix of the class 13 possessors to create a HL falling tone. The L of /tẽ-/ conditions LTS in (8d) but is blocked by the floating L of /-bā́l̩/, ‘valleys’, in (8c). We thus obtain the observed contrast between HL-M vs. HL-L° in these last two forms.

The L prefix tone pattern is used not only in associative constructions, but also following the locative prefix ā- (cf. Chia 1983):

(9) Locative ā-:

- | | | | | | |
|----|-----------|---|----------|--------------------------------|-----------|
| a. | /a-te-we/ | → | a-tê-wẽ° | ‘at the markets’ | (M-HL-L°) |
| | H L H | | | (cf. e-te-wé ‘markets’) | |
| b. | /a-e-we/ | → | e-we | ‘at the market’ | (M-M) |
| | H L H | | | (cf. e-wé ‘market’) | |
| c. | /a-i-sas/ | → | i-sas | ‘underneath’ | (M-M) |
| | H L HL | | | (cf. i-sās° ‘buttock, bottom’) | |

As indicated in (9b) and (9c), ā- assimilates to an immediately following prefix vowel and in all cases is realized M by virtue of being a prefix itself. The observed vowel fusion bleeds LTS and we obtain e-we, ‘at the market’, rather than *e-wẽ°.

The final prefix tone property in the last column of Table 2 is the most interesting... and intriguing. As subject, there is no IV and prefix tone is H except classes 1, 9, and 6a, which take L tone. All noun classes are illustrated in the future tense in Table 5.

class	underlying	as subject	gloss
1	/ˈwùl/	ka wùl è fěé	‘a person will fall’
2	/ˈghèl/	ka ghèl e fěé	‘people will fall’
3	/éː-lèŋ/	k’ e-lwéŋ é fěé	‘bamboo will fall’
4	/í-lèŋ/	k’ i-léŋ í fěé	‘bamboos will fall’
5	/í-sòŋ/	k’ i-sóŋ í fěé	‘a tooth will fall’
6	/á-sòŋ/	k’ a-sóŋ á fěé	‘teeth will fall’
7	/á-táʔ/	k’ a-táʔ a fěé	‘a snail will fall’
8	/eː-táʔ/	k’ e-twáʔ e fěé	‘snails will fall’
9	/ˈbí/	ka bí fěé	‘a dog will fall’
10	/ˈbíː/	ka bí se fěé	‘dogs will fall’
13	/tè-bíí/	ka tè-bíí té fěé	‘kolanuts will fall’
19	/fě-nyùyn/	ka fě-nyùyn fě fěé	‘a bird will fall’
6a	/mè-nyùyn/	ka mè-nyùyn fěé	‘birds will fall’

Table 5. Noun class realizations as subject in main clause

As indicated, the tones of the singular vs. plural subject nouns are different in genders 1/2, 9/10, and 19/6a. This is due to the difference between the L prefix in classes 1, 9, and 6a vs. the H prefix in classes 2, 10, and 19.⁶

The M tone on the future marker suggests either that it is a prefix, like locative /á-/ , or that its underlying tone is /ká/ or /káː/. The following examples show that a phrase-initial subject noun will also not take an initial vowel and will have an L prefix in classes 1, 9, and 6a.

(10) Subject nouns in present tense:

a. L prefixes in classes 1, 9, and 6a

wùl wēn fěé	‘a person is falling’
bí yēn fěé	‘a dog is falling’
mè-nyùyn mēn fěé	‘birds are falling’

b. H prefixes in classes 2, 10, and 19

ghúl ghēn fěé	‘people are falling’
bí sēn fěé	‘dogs are falling’
fě-nyùyn fēn fěé	‘a bird is falling’

The subject L- vs. H- prefix pattern occurs also after oblique markers, specifically after comitative *nè*, ‘with’ and dative marker *sēː*, ‘to’ (realized as [sə] with ML tone). Because of the L part of the ML contour tone, LTS will apply to classes

6. Besides the indicated coalescences of future *ka* with a following vowel, the data show some irrelevant tonal simplifications, e.g., HL and HM contours are simplified to H when a CV(C) stem is followed by a prefix with the shape V- (Hyman 1988).

other than 1, 9, and 6a. As seen in the following examples, these latter have an underlying L prefix.

class	underlying	after <i>nè</i> , ‘with’	after <i>sè</i> , ‘to’	gloss
1	/wùl/	<i>nè wùl</i>	<i>sè wùl</i>	‘to/with a person’
2	/ghèl/	<i>nè ghèl-e</i> ⁷	<i>sè ghèl-e</i>	‘to/with people’
3	/é-lèŋ/	<i>nè-lèŋ-é</i>	<i>sè-lèŋ-é</i>	‘to/with bamboo’
4	/í-lèŋ/	<i>nè-lèŋ-í</i>	<i>sè-lèŋ-í</i>	‘to/with bamboos’
5	/í-sòŋ/	<i>nè-sòŋ-í</i>	<i>sè-sòŋ-í</i>	‘to/with a tooth’
6	/á-sòŋ/	<i>nè-sòŋ-á</i>	<i>sè-sòŋ-á</i>	‘to/with teeth’
7	/á-tá?/	<i>nè-tá?-a</i>	<i>sè-tá?-a</i>	‘to/with a snail’
8	/e-tá?/	<i>nè-tá?-e</i>	<i>sè-tá?-e</i>	‘to/with snails’
9	/bí/	<i>nè bí</i>	<i>sè bí</i>	‘to/with a dog’
10	/bí-sé/	<i>nè bí-sé</i>	<i>sè bí-sé</i>	‘to/with dogs’
13	/tè-bíí/	<i>nè tè-bíí-té</i>	<i>sè tè-bíí-té</i>	‘to/with kolanuts’
19	/fé-tám/	<i>nè fé-tám-fé</i>	<i>sè fé-tám-fé</i>	‘to/with a fruit’
6a	/mè-nywìn/	<i>nè mè-tám</i>	<i>sè mè-tám</i>	‘to/with fruits’

Table 6. Noun class realizations after *nè*, ‘with’ and *sè*, ‘to’

Both *nè* and *sè* (ML) require the same suffixes attested on adjectives and illustrated in (5) on class 19 nouns appearing after *nè*, ‘with’. Although a following noun prefix, when present, is always L, we see in the comparison of 19/6a nouns that the effect on a following tone can be different. Thus, we obtain an H on *fé-tám* in the singular, but an M on *mè-tám* in the plural (which combines with the -L suffix to produce an ML falling tone). Compare also the following nouns which have an underlying L stem.

(11) Class 19/6a /-ghām/, ‘mat’, appearing after *nè*, ‘with’, and *sè*, ‘to’:

- a. *ne* *fe-gham* *-fe* → *nè* *fé-ghām* *-fé* ‘with a mat’
 L H L H
 se *fe-gham* *-fe* → *sè* *fé-ghām* *-fé* ‘to a mat’
 HL H L H
- b. *ne* *me-gham* → *nè* *mè-ghām* ‘with mats’
 L L L L
 se *me-gham* → *sè* *mè-ghām* ‘to mats’
 HL L L L

As indicated, the tones are quite different on *fé-ghām* in (11a) vs. *mè-ghām* in (11b).

7. For some reason, the floating /H/ prefixes of class 2 /-ghèl/, ‘people’, and class 10 /-bí-sé/, ‘dogs’, have no effect here, presumably fusing with the L of *nè* and *sè*. The tone on *ghèl* and *bí* is therefore M.

The final use of the skewed L- vs. H- pattern is in vocatives. My notes are limited here, but I have documented the following.

class	underlying	general	vocative	a + vocative	gloss
1	/-wáy n/	wáy n	wáy n °		‘child’
2	/-ghó y n/	ghó y n	ghó y n		‘children’
7	/-kôs /	a-kôs	a-kôs-â ⁸		‘slave’
9	/-bí /	bí	bí	a bí i	‘dog’
9	/-nyâm /			a nyâm	‘animal’
19	/-nyû y n /	f e-nyû y n	f e-nyû y n f é	a f e-nyû y n f é	‘bird’
6a	/-nywî n /			a mē-nyû y n	‘birds’

Table 7. Nouns compared with their vocatives

Those forms I have labeled vocative occur before an imperative verb, while those that are preceded by M tone [a] occur after: bí, gwi á f ē ñ, ‘dog, come here!’ vs. gwi á f ē n, a bí i, ‘come here, dog!’ I suspect that further research will confirm that vocatives fall into the same class as subjects and obliques, as far as prefix tone is concerned.

3. Discussion

The above concludes the brief survey of noun classes and prefix tone in Kom. The results of this survey are summarized in (12).

- (12) Grammatical tone is assigned to noun class prefixes as follows:
- all nouns receive /L/ tone following an associative marker (AM)
 - class 1, 9, and 6a nouns receive /L/ tone as subject of a main clause, after the oblique markers nē and s ē, and probably when used as vocatives
 - approximately 12% of Kom nouns have a lexical /L/ prefix (over 70% of these have stem-initial NC)
 - in all other situations, a noun prefix will be /H/.

In addition, we have seen that there is an initial vowel (IV) that occurs only at the beginning of a sentence (or when nouns are given as a list). These data logically raise the following questions.

8. I transcribed an L here, although it may have been L°. The vocative tones elsewhere appear to be different from what we would expect. Thus, bí i, ‘dog’, is pronounced with a ML fall (rather than simple M), while f e-nyû y n-f é, ‘bird!’, is pronounced M-H-H rather than M-HM-H. Finally, my notes show the expected bí i y em, gwi, ‘my dog, come!’, with a ML fall before ‘my’, but I also have bí i s ē m-s ē y i gwi, ‘my dogs, come!’, where I would have expected the stem tone to be HL. This needs to be checked further.

- (13) Questions that naturally arise:
- Why do class 1, 9, and 6a receive /L/ in the above-indicated contexts (vs. other classes)?
 - Why do all nouns receive /L/ following an AM?
 - Why are there exceptional nouns with lexical /L/ prefixes?
 - Why is /H/ the default tone on noun prefixes?
 - What is the initial vowel? Is it related to the augment in Narrow Bantu?

In this section, I will first consider possible origins of the initial vowel, then turn to the phenomenon of prefix deletion in Ring Bantu.

3.1. The initial vowel

It is important to recognize the inherent difficulty involved in determining whether the *e*-augment in Kom has anything to do with the augments found throughout Narrow Bantu (de Blois 1970, Grégoire & Janssens 1999). Its distribution on nouns is very limited, appearing only in (some) initial environments, and it is not clear whether its presence vs. absence has any grammatical or semantic function at all. Its tone is clearly /H/ (phonetic M), as can be seen from nouns with a lexical /L/ prefix, e.g., *e-fè-bòyn*, ‘ground squirrel’; *e-è-kî*, ‘wife’; *a-à-ntàs*, ‘spoon’. While its absence has no tonal effect when the noun prefix is also /H/, the latter exceptional nouns appear with an L tone prefix in internal positions such as direct object, where the default prefix tone assignment is otherwise /H/. It may be important that the phonetic realization of the initial vowel is closer to [ʌ] than the more closed ‘schwa’, which occurs in CV- prefixes, and there is evidence from closely related Bum that it should be reconstructed as **á*-. Table 8 summarizes the distribution of the initial vowel as well as certain other properties in six Ring Bantu languages.⁹

	IV	Su H/L	Obl H/L	Su PrefDel	Obl PrefDel	Mod PrefDel
Kom	+	+	+	-	-	-
Oku	-	+	+	-	-	-
Bum	+	+	(+)	+	+	-
Bafmeng	+	+	(+)	+	+	-
Aghem	-	+	+	+	+	+
Weh	-	+	+	+	+	+

Table 8. Comparison of prefix properties in six Ring Bantu languages

The first column indicates which languages have an overt segmental IV. The next two columns show that all languages distinguish H and L noun prefixes on subjects and obliques. (Pluses in parentheses are partially indicated in the data available, but require further documentation.) The last three columns refer to a yet

9. Not shown in Table 8 is the fact that these languages, like all of WGB, have L noun prefixes after an AM.

to be illustrated process of prefix deletion, which is not found in Kom, but which has potential significance for the analysis (see §3.2). As seen, these three columns group the six languages into three pairs: (i) Kom and Oku lack prefix deletion; (ii) Bum and Bafmeng have prefix deletion in subject and oblique positions; and (iii) Aghem and Weh have prefix deletion in these two positions but also in other positions whenever occurring with a modifier.¹⁰

In the two other languages that include an overt IV, its properties in Bafmeng appear to be similar to those in Kom: it was regularly elicited on nouns in citation and at the beginning of a phrase (when not the subject of a main clause). Its phonetic value varied between [ʌ] and [a]. Bum, on the other hand, differed in two ways. First, the initial vowel is phonetically [a] in all contexts. Second, it occurred in my elicitations only on prefixless class 1 and 9 nouns—and not on all of these: a-nyām, ‘animal’ (pl. se-nyām); a-sōn, ‘friend’ (pl. se-sōn); a-fê, ‘hoe’ (pl. se-fê) vs. kâ, ‘basket’ (pl. sê-kâ); fî, ‘caterpillar’ (pl. se-fî); mbòŋ, ‘dwarf cow’ (pl. sê-mbòŋ).¹¹ It is possible that there is variation here and that the speaker would have accepted these nouns with and without a-.¹² Rather puzzling, however, is that the augment was consistently absent when the noun began with a Ce- prefix but uniformly present on both prefixless and Ce- nouns when modified, as illustrated in (14).

(14) Absence vs. presence of IV a- on Bum nouns with CV- prefixes:

a.	se-nyām	‘animals’	b.	a-se-nyām	sām-so	‘my animals’
	te-bīī	‘kolanuts’		a-te-bīī	tām-to	‘my kolanuts’
	fe-nyēm	‘bird’		a-fe-nyēm	fām-fo	‘my bird’
	m̄-nyēm	‘birds’		a-m̄-nyēm	mām-ò	‘my birds’

As indicated, class 10 se- is a prefix in Bum (as well as in Bafmeng), whereas it is a suffix in Kom and Oku (as well as in languages to their east, e.g., Lamnso, Babanki). Class 6a has a syllabic nasal prefix (also in Bafmeng). The possessives in (14b) show the appearance of the initial vowel a- as soon as a possessive pronoun is added. The same is true of other modifiers, e.g., a-te-bīī té-nà, ‘these kolanuts’; a-te-bīī tē-bâ, ‘two kolanuts’.

10. Aghem, Weh, Bafmeng, and Bum are spoken to the north of Kom, while Oku is spoken to its east (and has no shared boundary with the other four). All but the Aghem data were collected in Cameroon in 1977. I am grateful to the following speakers for their help: Ndiba Noah Ndifon (Oku), Joseph Wango (Bum), Helen Kia (Bafmeng), and Dominic Cham (Weh). Research on Aghem reported by Hyman (1979a), Anderson (1979), and Watters (1979) was conducted in Los Angeles in 1978 with subsequent follow-ups with Timothy Inah Buo, Ivo Ngha, and Mih Wallang.

11. As in the Kom examples, ‘e’ will be used to designate schwa in prefixes, suffixes, and other CV grammatical morphemes, e.g. ghê- [ɣə-], ‘class 2 prefix’, -sé [-sə], ‘class 10 suffix’, nê [nə], ‘with’. These are written with ‘i’ by Chia (1984), Schulz (1997), and Jones (2001).

12. There are some inconsistencies where an a- appears on some class 1 or 9 in the Comparative Ring notebook that is absent in my personal notes. Perhaps I re-checked and made the appropriate changes.

The significance of the *a-* form in Bum is that the initial vowel probably does not have an origin in a determiner concord prefix, as proposed for Narrow Bantu (de Blois 1970). Rather, it is necessary to look at morphemes of the shape [a] to find a likely source. It can be noted that Kom, Bum, and Bafmeng are the three languages in Table 8 which have a class 7 *a-* prefix, as seen in (15a). Oku, Aghem, and Weh all have a *kə-* or *ki-* prefix (cf. Proto-Bantu **ki-*), as seen in (15b).

(15) Class 7 prefix on the noun ‘head’ in the six Ring Bantu languages:

a.	Kom	a-t ú ~	b.	Oku	ke-t ô
	Bum	a-t ô		Aghem	k í-t ú
	Bafmeng	a-t ú ~		Weh	k ɔ-t ɔw

Class 7 *a-*, which is also found in the Momo branch of Western Grassfields (Stallcup 1978), in Eastern Grassfields (Hyman 1980c), in Beboïd (Hombert 1980), and elsewhere, has long puzzled scholars working in the area (cf. the studies in Hyman 1980b). While one speculation is that it represents the merger of an earlier **ka-* prefix (which is unattested in the area) with **ki-*, it is also possible that the combination **á-ki-* led to the present situation—which would, of course, mean that the above-mentioned groups would have all had to have had an *á-* IV.

Where would this *á-* have come from, if not from **ka-*? It is not likely that it would have derived from class 6 **á-*, which marks a plural. There is a locative proclitic (or pre-prefix) *á-* in these languages, but as we saw in (9), locative *á-* is expected to be followed by an L tone prefix, rather than the H tone that is observed. In addition, it is hard to imagine the semantic link that might have caused this *á-* to be identified with class 7 or any other non-locative class.¹³

I wish therefore to propose an alternative hypothesis. Up to now I have mentioned only that nouns can take an *e-* [ʌ] or *a-* IV in Kom, Bafmeng, and Bum. In fact, all of these languages also use the initial vowel *a-* to mark a modifier in a headless noun phrase (NP). This is illustrated for the demonstrative ‘this/these’ in both Kom and Bum in Table 9.

13. There are other [a] morphemes in GB, e.g., the default subject marker *a*, ‘it’, that might be identified with class 7. It might also be noted that in some zone A Bantu languages, rather than class 7 **ki-*, *á-* seems to have replaced class 5 **di-*.

cl.	Kom		Bum		gloss
1	e-wáyn wēn	e-wēn°	a-wán wūnā	a-wūnā`	'this child'
2	e-ghóyn ghēn°	e-ghēn°	a-yén ghénā ¹⁴	a-ghénā`	'these children'
3	e-lwéñ wēn°	e-wēn°	u-láñ wūnā	a-wūnā`	'this bamboo'
4	i-léñ yenì°	e-yén°	i-láñ yínā	a-yínā`	'these bamboos'
5	i-wóm yenì°	e-yénì°	i-wúm yínā	a-yínā`	'this egg'
6	a-wóm kenā°	a-kénā°	a-wúm ghénā	a-ghénā`	'these eggs'
7	a-à-ñkém kenā°	a-kénā°	a-kám ghénā	a-ghénā`	'this crab'
8	e-è-ñkfém wēn°	e-wēn°	u-kám wūnā	a-wūnā`	'these crabs'
9	e-nyám yèn	e-yèn	a-nyám yínā	a-yínā`	'this animal'
10	e-nyám sènsè°	e-sènsè°	a-sè-nyám sénā	a-sénā`	'these animals'
13	e-te-bíí tèntè°	e-tèntè°	a-te-bíí ténā	a-ténā`	'these kolanuts'
19	e-fe-nyúyn fènfè°	e-fènfè°	a-fe-nyóm fénā	a-fénā`	'this bird'
6a	e-me-nyúyn e-mèn	e-mèn	a-m-nyóm mènā`	a-mènā`	'these birds'

Table 9. The demonstratives 'this/these' in Kom and Bum

When the demonstrative follows the noun, there is no IV. However, when the demonstrative occurs alone with the meaning 'this one, these ones', Bum shows the a- IV, while Kom uses a- in class 7 and e- in all other classes.¹⁵ It is not clear which situation is older, i.e. whether we can reconstruct only *á- or also need to reconstruct *é-. The more important issue is its functioning to mark the absence of a head noun. Besides demonstratives, the initial vowel appears on other modifiers in headless NPs. The possessive 'mine', associative 'his/hers' (= 'of him/her') and 'which one(s)' are illustrated from Kom in Table 10.

14. I have given the form meaning 'these women', since 'children' is in class 6a in Bum.

15. I will not go into the tonal differences observed here, which are partly due to the difference between classes 1, 9, 6a and the others. As discussed in Hyman (1980a), it is interesting how Kom merges classes 6 and 7 with the class 7 ke- concord, while Bum merges them with the class 6 concord ghe-.

class	‘mine’	‘of him/her’	‘which one(s)’
1	e-wôm	e-wú ḡwen	ē`-kf à°
2	e-ghém	e-ghé ḡwen	e-ghè-kà°
3	e-wóm	e-wé ḡwen	ē`-kf à°
4	i-yém-í	i-yí ḡwen-i	ī`-kà°
5	i-yém-í	i-yí ḡwen-i	ī`-kà°
6	a-kém-á	a-ké ḡwen-a	ā`-kà°
7	a-kém-á	a-ké ḡwen-a	ā`-kà°
8	e-wóm	e-wú ḡwen	ē`-kf à°
9	e-yém	i-yí ḡwen	ī`-kà°
10	e-sém-sé	e-sé ḡwen-se	e-sè-kà°
13	e-tém-té	e-té ḡwen-te	e-tè-kà°
19	e-fém-fé	e-fé ḡwen-fe	e-fè-kà°
6a	e-mém	e-mé ḡwen	e-ḡ-kà°

Table 10. Other modifiers with IV in Kom

The purpose of the initial vowel is to mark the nominality and initiality of modifiers within their noun phrase. My claim is that in Kom, Bum, and Bafmeng this marking has been extended to nouns themselves, which explains why the initial vowel is so identified with initial position within the phrase.¹⁶

The proposal is that the initial vowel was analogically extended from headless NPs to headed ones appearing in isolation or at the beginning of a phrase. This hypothesis is supported by the fact that Aghem and Weh, which lack the initial vowel, have developed different ways of marking headless NPs beginning with a modifier.¹⁷ As Table 11 shows, two strategies are adopted.

16. Unfortunately I did not elicit forms like ‘this one fell’ or ‘mine fell’ to verify that the IV is missing in such cases, but I suspect it is. If, on the other hand, the IV were present in headless noun phrases used as subject, this would require some weakening of the hypothesis.

17. The prediction is that three of four situations will be found: (i) no IV on nouns or headless modifiers; (ii) IV on both nouns and modifiers in headless NPs; (iii) IV on modifiers in headless NPs only (i.e. without analogical extension to nouns). Predicted not to occur is (iv) IV on nouns, but not on modifiers in headless NPs.

class	‘my’	‘mine’	‘his/her’	‘his/hers’	‘this/these’
1	waŋa ¹⁸	ò-wáŋá	à wìn°	ò wìn°	wìn
2	ghaŋa	á-ghá ¹ ŋá gh̃	á ¹ wìn	á ¹ wìn gh̃	gh̃ín
3	waŋa	ó-wá ¹ ŋá w̃	ó ¹ wìn	ó ¹ wìn w̃	wìn
4	zaŋa	é-zá ¹ ŋá z̃	é ¹ wìn	é ¹ wìn z̃	z̃ín
5	zaŋa	é-zá ¹ ŋá-z̃	é ¹ wìn	é ¹ wìn z̃	z̃ín
6	ghaŋa	á-ghá ¹ ŋá gh̃	á ¹ wìn	á ¹ wìn gh̃	gh̃ín
7	kaŋa	kí-ká ¹ ŋá gh̃	kí- ¹ wìn	kí ¹ wìn k̃	kín
8	waŋa	ó-wá ¹ ŋá w̃	ó ¹ wìn	ó ¹ wìn w̃	wìn
9	yaŋa	è-záŋá	à wìn°	è wìn°	z̃ín
13	taŋa	tí-tá ¹ ŋá t̃	tí ¹ wìn	tí ¹ wìn t̃	t̃ín
19	faŋa	fí-fá ¹ ŋá f̃	fí ¹ wìn	fí ¹ wìn f̃	f̃ín
6a	maŋa	m-máŋá m̃	m wìn°	m wìn m̃	m̃ín

Table 11. Possessive, associative, and demonstrative without overt head in Aghem

As indicated, in Aghem, the possessive ‘my’ has the shape Caŋa and directly follows the noun, e.g., wé wá¹ŋá, ‘my child’ (class 1); mb̃ŋ záŋá, ‘my cow’. When occurring within a headless NP, however, modifiers acquire a noun class prefix and are required to have an overt determiner. In columns 2 and 4 of Table 11 we therefore see the ‘dummy determiner’ /-̃/, henceforth DD, discussed by Hyman (1979a, 1985). The forms for ‘his/her’ are built on the associative construction (‘of him/her’). When following a noun, the AM for classes 1 and 9 is /à/, hence wá à wìn°, ‘his child’; mb̃ŋ à wìn°, ‘his cow’. When occurring in isolation, the AM is ò for class 1 and è for class 9: ò wìn°, ‘his/hers’ (e.g., child), è wìn°, ‘his/hers’ (e.g., cow). Again, the DD is observed in all classes except 1 and 9.¹⁹ The last column shows the near speaker demonstrative, which remains the same whether modifying a noun or whether occurring in a headless NP. These forms therefore mean either ‘this/these’ or ‘this one/these ones’.

By equating the initial vowel on Kom nouns with the initial vowel that modifiers receive in headless NPs, we correctly predict that languages lacking an initial vowel will use other strategies in such constructions. Thus, Aghem invokes prefixes, AMs, and the DD in the case of possessives, but allows demonstratives to stand unchanged, as was just shown. The third language that lacks an initial vowel is Oku. Table 12 shows that Oku uses suffixation to mark possessives and demonstratives in headless NPs.

18. The possessive root ‘my’ is realized -áŋá after an L tone, but -á¹ŋá after an H tone; cf. the second column where the L or H tone is provided by a prefix that resembles the AM.

19. The prefix in column two may optionally undergo prefix deletion (see below), while the AM in column four may not (Hyman 1979a).

class	‘my’	‘mine’	‘his/her’	‘his/hers’	‘this/these’	‘this one’/ ‘these ones’
1	wɔm	wɔm-wè	ǎ wīn	wê wīn	vìn	ə vìn
2	ghɔm	ghɔm-ghé	ǎ wīn	ghê wīn-è°	yìn	yín-è°
3	wɔm	wɔm-wé	ǎ wīn	wê wīn-è°	vìn	vín-è°
4	yɔm	yɔm-yé	ǎ wīn	žê wīn-è°	zìn	žín-è°
5	yɔm	yɔm-yé	ǎ wīn	žê wīn-è°	žìn	žín-è°
6	ghɔm	ghɔm-ghé	ǎ wīn	žê wīn-è°	yìn	yín-è°
7	kɔm	kɔm-ké	ǎ wīn	gê wīn-è°	kìn	kín-è°
8	wɔm	wɔm-wé	ǎ wīn	wê wīn-è°	vìn	vín-è°
9	yɔm	yɔm-yé	ǎ wīn	yê wīn	žìn	e-žìn
10	sɔm	sɔm-sé	sǎ wīn	šê wīn-è°	šìn	šín-è°
13	tɔm	tɔm-té	ǎ wīn	tê wīn-è°	tìn	tín-è°
19	fɔm	fɔm-fé	ǎ wīn	fê wīn-è°	fìn	fín-è°
6a	mɔm	mɔm-mè	mǎ wīn	mê wīn	mìn	əm-mìn

Table 12. Possessives and demonstratives in Oku

It is significant that Oku occurs to the east of Kom and is quite isolated from Aghem and Weh. Kom, in fact, splits it off from contact with all four of the other languages. As seen, all but classes 1, 9, and 6a have an /-é/ suffix that is used on headless associatives (e.g., ‘of him/her’) and on demonstratives (e.g., ‘this one/these ones’). The ‘his/hers’ forms also show an apparent AM that has an agreement marker followed by /-ε/. We will return to this below.

Finally, before moving on to discuss tone, it may be significant to point out that the use of an initial vowel to mark possessives and demonstratives in headless NPs extends to much of Eastern Grassfields Bantu (EGB), e.g., Bamileke-Dschang (Tadadjeu 1980). Both Bamileke-Dschang and Mankon (Leroy 1977) show a more open /ǎ/ object agreement before prefixless class 1 nouns vs. a more close /è/ object agreement before other classes. They also are among those languages which have a class 7 /ǎ-/ prefix. The relation between *kǎ- and *a- remains mysterious, but is amply documented in the forms in classes 6 and 7 in several of the above tables.

3.2. Prefix deletion

The remaining issue to discuss is how to identify the different tone patterns on prefixes. Before I address this in §4, I want to introduce one last piece of relevant information: prefix deletion. As indicated in Table 8, the languages which are to the north of Kom undergo a process whereby their noun prefixes fail to appear in certain situations.²⁰ In Aghem, a prefix will be deleted whenever the noun is

20. Voorhoeve (1980) reports prefix deletion also in Adere, a quite distant EGB language.

followed by an agreeing element other than a numeral (cf. *kí-fú kí-mò?*, ‘one rat’). The following examples are from Hyman (1979a).

class	noun	‘my’	‘his/her’	‘this/these’	gloss
1	fín	fín wá'ṇá	fìl à wìn°	fín wín	‘friend’
2	á-fín	fín ghá'ṇá	fín á 'wìn	fín ghín	‘friends’
3	ó-kṣ?	kṣ? 'wáṇá	kṣ? ó wín	kṣ? 'wín	‘ladder’
4	é-kṣ?	kṣ? 'záṇá	kṣ? é wín	kṣ? 'zín	‘ladders’
5	é-ghóm	ghóm 'záṇá	ghóm 'é 'wín	ghóm 'zín	‘egg’
6	á-ghóm	ghóm 'gháṇá	ghóm 'á 'wín	ghóm 'ghín	‘eggs’
7	kí-fú	fú ká'ṇá	fú kí wín	fú kín	‘rat’
8	ó-fú	fú wá'ṇá	fú ú 'wín	fú wín	‘rats’
9	ndón	ndón zá'ṇá	ndón ò wìn°	ndón zín	‘horn’
13	tí-ndón	ndón t á'ṇá	ndón 'tí 'wín	ndón 'tín	‘horns’
19	fí-ghâm	ghâm fáṇá	ghâm 'fí 'wín	ghâm fín°	‘mat’
6a	ṅ-ghâm	ghâm máṇá	ghâm ñ wìn°	ghâm mìn°	‘mats’

Table 13. Prefix deletion before possessive, associative, and demonstrative in Aghem

As seen in the class 19 example /fí-ghâm/, ‘mat’, in general, when the prefix is deleted, its H tone is still realized on a following L stem: ghâm fáṇá, ‘my mat’; nwín 'f áṇá, ‘my bird’. However, this is not the case in corresponding class 6a plural: ghâm máṇá, ‘my mats’; nwìn máṇá, ‘my birds’. For some reason, classes 1 and 9 do not show these alternations in possessive and demonstrative contexts. However, in associative forms such as ‘his/her’ (= ‘of him/her’), we get tonal alternations in classes 1, 9, and 6a that are not found in the other classes. It is likely that we are dealing with the same tonal skewing seen on subjects in Kom: L for classes 1, 9, and 6a vs. H for the other classes.²¹

As indicated in Table 8, there are differences in how prefix deletion works in different Ring languages. All four languages show prefix deletion in subject and oblique positions. As we have just seen, Aghem and Weh also show prefix deletion whenever an agreeing element follows.²² Table 14 shows that this is not automatic in Bafmeng and Bum.

21. I have also occasionally considered the possibility that 1 and 9 might lack a tone altogether, while 6a has an L tone.

22. The one exception is numerals, before which prefix deletion is possible, but not preferred: kí-fú kí-mò?, ‘one rat’; ñ-nwín m-mbèghà, ‘two birds’, etc.

class	Bafmeng	Bum	gloss
1	Λ-v á ī ŋ v ə̀m̃	wā mù	‘my child’
2	Λ-w ó ī ŋ gh ə̀mm̃	wān á mā	‘my children’
3	e-l á ŋ v ə̀m̃ (v é)	u-l á ŋ ú mu	‘my bamboo’
4	---	i-l á ŋ í mi	‘my bamboos’
5	i-gh ú m̃ z ə̀m̃	i-wú m̃ í mi	‘my egg’
6	Λ-gh ú m̃ gh ə̀mm̃	a-wú m̃ á ma	‘my eggs’
7	a-k á m̃ k ə̀mk é	a-k á m̃ á ma	‘my crab’
8	i-kw á m̃ v ə̀m̃ (v é)	u-k á m̃ ú mu	‘my crabs’
9	Λ-ny á m̃ z ə̀m̃	a-ny á m̃ à m̃ i	‘my animal’
10	Λ-se-ny á m̃ s ə̀ms é	a-s è-ny á m̃ s á ms o	‘my animals’
13	Λ-te-p í ī t ə̀mt é	a-te-p í ī t á mt o	‘my kolanuts’
19	a-fe-n ə̀ŋ f ə̀mf é	a-fe-ny ə̀m̃ f á mf o	‘my bird’
6a	m̃-n ə̀ŋ m ə̀m̃	a-m-ny ə̀m̃ m á m̃ o	‘my birds’

Table 14. Noun + possessive in Bafmeng and Bum

On the other hand, prefix deletion occurs in both subject and oblique positions. This is illustrated from Bafmeng in Table 15.

class	subject	gloss	oblique	gloss
1	w ə̀ v á p f i	‘a person has fallen’	s é- w ə̀	‘to a person’
2	gh í- gh ə̀ p f i	‘people have fallen’	s é- gh ə̀ n ə̀	‘to children’
3	l ú ə̀ v á p f i	‘a bridge has fallen’	s é- l ú ə̀ v è°	‘to a bridge’
5	gh ú m̃ z ə̀ p f i	‘an egg has fallen’	s é- gh um z é	‘to an egg’
6	gh ú m̃ gh ə̀ p f i	‘eggs have fallen’	s é- gh um gh é	‘to eggs’
7	k á m̃ k ə̀ p f i	‘a crab has fallen’	s é- k á m̃ k é	‘to a crab’
8	kw á m̃ v á p f i	‘crabs have fallen’	s é- kw á m̃ v é	‘to crabs’
9	ny á m̃ ə̀ p f i	‘an animal has fallen’	s é- ny à m̃	‘to an animal’
10	ny á m̃ s ə̀ p f i	‘animals have fallen’	s é- ny am se	‘to animals’
13	p í ī t ə̀ p f i	‘kolanuts have fallen’	s é- p i i t é	‘to kolanuts’
19	n í n̄ f ə̀ p f i	‘a bird has fallen’	s é- n i ŋ f é	‘to a bird’
6a	n í ŋ m ə̀ p f i	‘birds have fallen’	s é- n i ŋ ə̀ m̃	‘to birds’

Table 15. Subject and oblique prefix deletion in Bafmeng

In Table 14 we observe both prefix deletion and the appearance of a postposed element that resembles the Aghem DD seen in Table 11. These forms further confirm that prefix deletion leaves behind a tonal distinction on classes 1, 9, and 6a vs. the other classes (cf. the realizations of 9/10 ‘animal(s)’, for instance). The same oblique pattern is found even when the oblique is zero marked, e.g., Bafmeng: m ə̀ p è ŋ k á m̃ k é, ‘I have come with a crab’.

The presence vs. absence of prefix deletion in Bafmeng and Bum might be explained on the basis of grammatical position—or it might have to do with the

presence of the initial vowel in Table 14. That this latter interpretation is probably correct is seen in the Bafmeng forms in Table 16.

class	object ²³	gloss	relativized object	gloss
1	mǎ fe vāíŋ	‘I have seen a child’	wǎ mǎ fe	‘the person I see’
2	mǎ fe ghǎnǎ	‘I have seen children’	ghǎí mǎ fe	‘the people I see’
3	mǎ fe wúǎ vé	‘I have seen a fire’	wúǎ ǎ mǎ fe	‘the fire I see’
5	mǎ fe ghóm zé	‘I have seen an egg’	ghúm í mǎ fe	‘the egg I see’
6	mǎ fe ghóm ghé	‘I have seen eggs’	ghúm ǎ mǎ fe	‘the eggs I see’
7	mǎ fe kám ké	‘I have seen a crab’	kám ké mǎ fe	‘the crab I see’
8	mǎ fe kwám vé	‘I have seen crabs’	kwám vé mǎ fe	‘the crabs I see’
9	mǎ fe nyám	‘I have seen an animal’	nyám mǎ fe	‘the animal I see’
10	mǎ fe nyám se	‘I have seen animals’	nyám se mǎ fe	‘the animals I see’
13	mǎ fe píí té	‘I have seen kolanuts’	píí té mǎ fe	‘the kolanuts I see’
19	mǎ fe níŋ fé	‘I have seen a bird’	níŋ fé mǎ fe	‘the bird I see’
6a	mǎ fe níŋ ðm	‘I have seen birds’	nín ðm mǎ fe	‘the birds I see’

Table 16. Bafmeng nouns in object position

The first column of forms shows both prefix deletion and a postposition after each object noun. Since this is the only tense in which I elicited object nouns, I cannot tell for sure whether prefix deletion occurs here because the nouns are in object position, or because there is something special about this tense. In Aghem, for example, nouns are required to occur with an agreeing determiner in so-called ‘focused tenses’, thereby creating oppositions such as the sentences in (16).

(16) Present perfect in Aghem (Anderson 1979):

- | | |
|---------------|---|
| a. [-focus] | b. [+focus] |
| ò kǎ? fí-nwín | ò ŋ kǎ? nwín [!] fǎ ‘he has seen a bird’ |
| ò kǎ? ñ-nwín | ò ŋ kǎ? nwín mǎ ‘he has seen birds’ |

The sentences in (16a) have ‘even focus’ (or possibly focus on the postverbal object), while the truth value is included within the scope of focus in (16b)—which might therefore also be translated as ‘he *has* seen a bird(s)’ (Watters 1979, Hyman & Watters 1984). In any case, it is neither clear whether Bafmeng has such a distinction, nor, if so, whether the first column of forms in Table 16 should be identified with the [-focus] or [+focus] variant in Aghem.

The object relative forms in Table 16 strongly suggest that focus is not involved. In Table 14 the nouns occur both with a modifier and with an initial

23. The following variants are attested on objects: wúǎ ǎ, ‘fire’ (class 3); ghóm ǎ, ‘eggs’ (class 6); and kám á, ‘crab’ (class 7).

vowel. In the relativized object forms there is no IV (whereas there would be in Kom!). As shown, there is prefix deletion, and the relativized noun is followed by a marker that agrees in noun class. This suggests that there is a complementarity between the presence of the initial vowel and prefix deletion in Bafmeng (and Bum). Unless ‘protected’ by an initial vowel, a prefix is free to fall in case there is an agreeing element.

With this result, we can now entertain hypotheses concerning prefix tones.

4. Conclusion

We are now ready to address the questions that were raised in (13).

Question (13a): Why do class 1, 9, and 6a receive /L/ in the above-indicated contexts (vs. other classes)? This includes subject and oblique positions in Kom and Oku, and all positions where there has been prefix deletion in the remaining languages. The answer is that these are the historical tones of prefixes, i.e. our starting point in WGB (and possibly other parts of Benue-Congo).

Question (13b): Why do all nouns receive /L/ following an AM? The most likely answer to this is that there was a historical L tone that occurred between the AM and the following noun. In this context it may be relevant to cite the following forms from Oku in Table 17.

class	noun	associative	gloss
1	wan	wāñ kè-kem	‘child of the crab’
2	ghɔn	ghɔn ə kè-kem	‘children of the crab’
3	eb-lɛŋ	eb-lɛŋ ə kè-kem	‘bamboo of the crab’
5	i-šɪɛ	i-šɪɛ ə kè-kem	‘eye of the crab’
6	a-šɪɛ	a-šɪɛ ə kè-kem	‘eyes of the crab’
7	ke-bām	ke-bām ə kè-kem	‘bag of the crab’
8	e-bwām	e-bwām ə kè-kem	‘bags of the crab’
9	nyām	nyām ə kè-kem	‘animal of the crab’
10	nyām-se	nyām se kè-kem	‘animals of the crab’
13	te-bíí	te-bíí kè-kem	‘kolanuts of the crab’
19	fe-nɔn	fe-nɔn ə kè-kem	‘bird of the crab’
6a	m-nɔn	m-nɔn mè kè-kem	‘birds of the crab’

Table 17. Associative construction in Oku

As was also seen in the ‘his/her’ forms in Table 12, Oku has a consonantal concord in associatives only in classes 10 and 6a (sé and mè, respectively). More importantly, however, Oku is the only Ring language I have found where H tone AMs do not spread their tone onto the prefix of the following noun. What is keeping the H from spreading?

Classes 1, 9, and 6a had an *L AM. What I would like to suggest is that the H AM was historically *HL. By a process that was old enough to affect all of WGB, a following H tone prefix assimilated to the *L or *HL AM. This could not have been done by normal L tone spreading, because we would therefore have

expected the H to go on to the following stem (cf. the derivations in (5)). The earlier process would have been a ‘vertical’ assimilation: prefixal *H > L after (H)L. Where would this L have come from? Meeussen (1967) reconstructs the Proto-Bantu AM as a concord prefix + *a, which seems to go well beyond Bantu (Welmers 1963). The associative construction in Modele, a Menchum language spoken south of Aghem, is like Oku in lacking a concord prefix (in any class), but having just a vocalic AM, which Boum (1981) analyses as /a/. One of the differences between GB and Narrow Bantu concerns the apparent absence of this *a in the former. Besides Modele, perhaps the Oku ‘his/hers’ forms in Table 12 give us further evidence. Recall that these consist of a concord prefix followed by /-ε/. The tone is HL in classes 1, 9, and 6a, suggesting that a H tone is coming from the left. The tone of the other classes is H, with a floating L after it. Now, it turns out that the class 6 suffix *a- is realized ε- in Oku: i-s i ē, ‘eye’, pl. ε-s i ē (5/6); i-gh i n, ‘breast’, pl. ε-gh i n ~ t e-gh i n (5/6~13). Perhaps the stand-alone AMs w-ε, gh-ε, etc. should be reconstructed with an L tone *ā, which is realized [ε] in Oku.²⁴

The other situation where nouns all acquire an L prefix is after the locative marker /ā-/, which may or may not be related to the Proto-Bantu AM *a. An alternative source from class 16 *pa is less likely, since we would expect this to come out as f ā- in Kom; cf. a f ē y n, ‘here’ (Chia 1983). I assume that the locative also reconstructs with *HL tone.

Question (13c): Why are there exceptional nouns with lexical /L/ prefixes? As indicated, we believe this has to do with NC initials, and we cannot rule out borrowings from EGB which would have had L tone prefixes. More work is needed in this area.

Question (13d): Why is /H/ the default tone on noun prefixes? The answer would be that other than classes 1, 9, and 6a, noun class prefixes reconstruct as *H. What this would mean is that we would have to find an explanation for any divergences from this situation. I have already suggested how post-AM noun prefixes may have become L in Western Grassfields. What is needed now is an explanation for why Narrow Bantu noun prefixes are L (cf. §5).

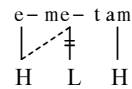
Question (13e): What is the initial vowel? Is it related to the augment in Narrow Bantu? I have addressed this question in some detail in §3. The one remaining point concerns the tonal properties of the initial vowel. With few exceptions, nouns have /H/ prefixes in Kom when they are preceded by the augment /ε-/ [ɛ̃]. If classes 1, 9, and 6a reconstruct with *L tone, we cannot allow class 6a *ā-m ā- to become ā-m ā- by H tone spreading (HTS). This is because the L of the prefix would be expected to lower a following H root, which never happens. The noun /m ē -t ā m + ʔ/, ‘fruits’, surfaces as m ē -t ā m in subject and oblique positions. Here we see that the L of the prefix lowers /-t ā m/ to M.

24. The Proto-Bantu AM *a is reconstructed without tone: the prefix + a sequence has L tone in classes 1 and 9, H tone in others. If I am correct in reconstructing *ā, then it would be understandable why this L has no tonal effect on what follows. Since Narrow Bantu noun prefixes are *L in all environments, the L of *ā would therefore have simply been absorbed into the following L prefix.

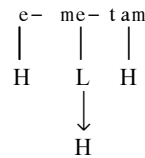
However, if we posit /*é-mè-t ám*/ with the H IV, by normal HTS we would expect **é-mé-t ám*, rather than the correct *e-me-t ám*. What is needed is an analogue to prefix lowering after an AM: when the H IV is present, the following L prefix of classes 1, 9, and 6a undergo a vertical raising to H, with no trace of the L left behind.

(17) Deriving H prefixes after the initial vowel:

a. incorrect



b. correct



We have to make one additional observation: In Kom there are environments, such as object position, where the initial vowel cannot occur (because it must be phrase-initial), but where all prefixes are H tone. Either the initial vowel was once there and fell out or there was an H tone object marker—or both are the same thing. In any case, one can get the all-H prefix pattern without an overt *e-* on the surface. In fact, checking over elicitations with different speakers, I see cases where I got either *e-fe-nyúŷn* or *fe-nyúŷn* in response to ‘How do you say “bird”?’

Question (13e), also present in my title, is probably not resolvable based solely on the formal properties of the initial vowel in Kom and related languages. The fact that the initial vowel occurs before the prefix and that it has H tone is certainly suggestive, but this only allows us to conclude that at some point in the history of Kom an H tone morpheme was placed before nouns. Segmentally, we have seen some evidence that the morpheme might have had the shape *á-*. The alternative would be to say that a full set of IVs merged into *a-* (ultimately *ə-*), as appears to have happened in Umbundu (R11), where the initial vowel is *o-* in most environments (Schadeberg 1986).

Other than its vocalic and tonal shape, the only other criterion we can exercise concerns the function of the initial vowel. The Narrow Bantu augment was clearly a determiner. Its earlier uses seem to have had to do with marking referentiality or definiteness. As such, we clearly expect it to occur in subject position. Since both the augment and its H tone are prohibited in subject position, we might propose a historical scenario to get reduction of the initial vowel in subject position. The alternative, which I find more attractive, is to say that the initial vowel had a different, perhaps predicative function that would have kept it out of subject position.

Besides the absence of Kom *e-*, there are also tonal reasons to suspect that the initial vowel never appeared in subject position. A number of Bantu languages from Gabon down to Angola have what Schadeberg (1986) has called ‘tone cases’. Blanchon (1998, 1999) has proposed a succession of tonal additions at the left edge of nouns to derive the observed behaviour. One property that these languages generally have in common is that subject position is tonally unmarked—i.e. it

provides the basic or historical tones of nouns without the addition of the extra tonal prefixes. The same seems to be true of Kom: in subject position you get the historical *L for classes 1, 9, and 6a vs. the *H prefix in other classes. What this suggests is that the subject escaped the innovative IV whose function I have hypothesized to have been to mark unheaded NPs. In this sense Ring a- ~ e- is much more like the tonal innovations in Western Bantu than the augment found throughout Narrow Bantu.

5. An alternative proposal

In the preceding section, I proposed that Proto-Ring noun prefixes were L in classes 1, 9, and 6a, and H in the remaining classes. Except for the anomalous tone of class 6a, this reconstruction is equivalent to de Wolf's (1971) reconstruction for Proto-Benue-Congo (PBC). This latter position has, however, come under close scrutiny by Williamson (1993), who suggests that noun prefixes may have been *L in all classes in PBC. As part of her evidence—and more close to home—she cites Hombert (1976), who sees the L tone prefix that follows the AM to be a direct reflex of the historical *L tone prefix, based on Ngie, a WGB language of the Momo subgroup. In other positions Hombert proposes that there was an *H tone augment that fused with the following *L to create the observed M tone prefixes in present-day Ngie. Logically, this is quite opposite to what I have outlined in §4: according to Hombert's analysis, the post-AM L- tone is proto and the H- vs. L- of other positions derived. My analysis is just the opposite. Stallcup (1978) critically evaluates alternative tonal reconstructions in terms of their relative merits. The advantage of Hombert's proposal is that the post-AM prefixal L- can be related not only to Proto-Bantu, but also to Proto-EGB, where noun prefixes are L in all positions. Williamson (1993) takes this further, citing from various branches of BC, and advances an alternative hypothesis that L tone prefixes may be reconstructable as far back as Proto-BC itself.

Concerning Kom, the Hombert/Williamson hypothesis is reduced to two questions: Are the L- vs. H- subject prefixes due to the addition of an H tone augment in the appropriate classes? Are the post-AM L prefixes a retention of *L prefixes in all positions in PGB?

First, the argument that the M tone prefixes derive from a fusing of H+L is problematic. As we have seen in Kom, the M prefixes are clearly from an underlying /H/. This can be seen clearly from the fact that underlying /H-L/ and /H-LH/ are realized [M-HL] and [M-HM] by HTS, as was seen in (3). The M tone is in fact due to a very common process of prefix tone-lowering that can be documented from throughout Narrow and Grassfields Bantu and beyond. In Ngamambo, another Momo language, the tone is H on CV- prefixes, M on V- prefixes, and L on nasal prefixes (Asongwed & Hyman 1976). This shows that prefix tone lowering can take place in stages, ultimately arriving at L. This is the case in Babanki, a Ring language very closely related to Kom, in which all noun prefixes are L. Even though this is true phonetically, one not only can reconstruct

*H prefixes, but even defend an analysis where the appropriate L tone prefixes are underlyingly /H/ (Hyman 1979c). While the *H-LH noun *fɪ-nùn', 'bird', comes out as M-HM fɛ-nyũɲn in Kom, it is pronounced as L-H fɪ-nyɪn in Babanki. The H on the root -nyɪn clearly comes from the prefix, as can be ascertained from its realization as fɪ-nyɪn° after an L AM. A *H-L noun is realized L-L in isolation, thereby merging with exceptional *L-L nouns. However, when an H tone syllable is added, only the *H-L nouns become L-M, while the *L-L nouns remain L. The process is the following (Hyman 1979c).

(18) Derivation of /H-L/ → L-L in Babanki:

underlying	HTS	prefix-lowering	HL simplification
H-L + H	→ H-HL + H	→ L-HL + H	→ L-M + H

As indicated, first HTS applies, followed by prefix-lowering. At this point, the L-HL-H sequence becomes L-M-H by contour simplification. As a result we get surface oppositions such as the following.

(19) Babanki /H-L/ vs. /L-L/ nouns (e = schwa):

- a. /kɛ-kɔs/ → kɛ-kɔs 'slave'
 /kɛ-kɔs kɛ~nyām/ → kɛ-kɔs kɛ nyām 'slave of the animal'
- b. /kɛ-mbɔ/ → kɛ-mbɔ 'bag'
 /kɛ-mbɔ kɛ~nyām/ → kɛ-mbɔ kɛ nyām 'bag of the animal'

While kɛ-kɔs, 'slave', and kɛ-mbɔ, 'bag', are pronounced identically in isolation, we see that the L root -kɔs is realized M in (19a) vs. (19b), where the root -mbɔ stays L. Given what we have seen in closely related Kom, we know what the cause is: the normal situation in (19a) involves a /H/ prefix, whereas the exceptional situation in (19b) is an /L/ prefix, conditioned by the initial NC.

The moral of this demonstration is that many languages that presently have L tone prefixes once had H tone prefixes. The lowering of tone on prefixes is such a widespread phenomenon that a language with only L tone prefixes has to be carefully scrutinized, as in the Babanki case. As evidence for her reconstruction, Williamson (1993) cites Anderson's (1980) description of Amo, to represent the Plateau group. While the L tone prefixes in this language may or may not be proto, it is possible that Amo independently underwent a process of prefix tone lowering, as has also affected the *H of the augment in many Narrow Bantu languages. It seems that reconstructing a single tone, *H or *L, each has a pitfall to avoid: if all prefixes are L, we need to determine whether this is proto, the result of tone lowering (reduction), or the result of an L augment; if all prefixes are H, we need to determine whether this is proto or the result of an H augment.

As Blanchon (1998, 1999) has shown, there may be cyclic additions of left-edge tones, one after the other, and the same reconstructed morphemes need not be

involved in every case. By contrast, if we can find correspondences of H and L prefixes by noun class, this is likely to be proto.²⁵

The second question is whether the L found in post-AM contexts is proto. In §4 I took the position that it could be derived: if we reconstruct H prefixes in classes other than 1, 9, and 6a, then these could have assimilated to a preceding L, as was schematized in (17b). In the discussion I took some comfort in the fact that an analogous process would have to raise the L prefix of classes 1, 9, and 6a after an H augment.

I recognize the appeal of the Hombert/Williamson position on these L tone prefixes. But why should a putative *L tone have been preserved after an AM or a locative prefix? From Narrow Bantu we know of two opposite things that an AM, locative, or other proclitic can do with respect to an augment:²⁶

- They can lock in the augment, preserving it when it is lost in the absence of a proclitic. As de Blois (1970) recognizes under the guise of a ‘latent augment’, there are many Bantu languages that have generally lost the augment but retain some or all of its properties when a noun is preceded by the AM or by *n̄a.

OR

- They can prohibit an augment, which locative classes regularly do, and in Bemba (M42) nouns generally have an augment, which is, however, absent after the AM.

While the first represents a way of preserving an inherited property, the second has the opposite function of blocking an innovation from occurring in the post-AM context. In the case of Kom, the AM appears to lock in an L tone and lock out a H tone. The question to be resolved, of course, is what the functions were of these L and H tones? Is the L part of the AM or of the old prefix? Is the H part of the prefix or an augment? These and other questions will probably remain open for some time.

25. I have long wondered why classes 1 and 9 should have L tone vs. the other classes. One reason could be simply phonological. If these classes reconstruct with *V- prefixes, while the others all had *CV-, then an original *H might have lowered only on the former. We know that initial vowels are even more prone to tone lowering than CV syllables (cf. the M of V- vs. H of CV- prefixes in Ngamambo).

26. A third effect could be to block prefix deletion in Ring Bantu. There is in fact some resistance to deleting the prefix of a post-AM noun in Aghem. It could be interesting if we could show that an old process of prefix deletion failed to affect nouns in post-AM, post-locative, and post-IV positions. In that case the hypothesis would be that the L- vs. H- subject prefixes of Kom are replacement prefixes, an augment that directly precedes the stem. Unfortunately, prefix-deletion appears to be coming in, rather than going out. But I suppose we should keep every option open.

References

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